

QSC Atlas: expert engagement and validation plan

Stakeholder review across summer 2026, with a validated output by end September 2026
Draft plan, June 2026. Companion to the QSC Atlas (qsc-atlas.vercel.app). [Author and affiliation]

1. Purpose and objective

The QSC Atlas and its companion report are complete as a first edition. This plan turns that edition into a collaborative, expert-validated instrument. Over the summer, fifteen senior figures from industry, the public sector and international organisations will review the Atlas and say whether it is relevant and what is wrong, and propose how to improve it. Their input is incorporated through a documented process, so the second edition carries both a sharper classification and the credibility of named expert review.

The objective is to tailor the Atlas as closely as possible to how practitioners and policymakers actually read the quantum-safe transition: to test the accuracy of each classification, the soundness of the two-axis method, and the usefulness of the regulatory layer, and to correct what the evidence and the experts show to be wrong. A secondary objective is to build the relationships and the standing that a validated, expert-backed instrument needs to grow into an advisory practice.

2. What the experts review

Reviewers see a short pack: the live Atlas, the companion report, and a one-page summary of the method. They are asked to assess five things.

Object of review	What we want tested
The two-axis classification	Whether coordination posture and standards role are the right axes, clearly defined and correctly separated.
Per-country classification	Whether each country's coordination bloc and standards role are accurate, and which are misattributed.
The regulatory layer	Whether the main regulation, legal status and obligation recorded for each country are correct and current.
The methodology	Whether the sources-only rule, the rubric and decision order, and the confidence grading are defensible.
Framing and theory	Whether the report's standards-governance framing is accurate and useful for the intended audiences.

3. The panel: fifteen experts

Five reviewers from each of three constituencies, chosen for seniority, independence, and spread across the coordination blocs (NIST-led, EU, sovereign-adjacent, and engaged-but-unaligned). Targets are described by role and organisation type; specific individuals are confirmed in Phase 0.

Constituency	N	Target profiles (by role and organisation type)
Industry	5	Cryptography or PKI vendor; cloud or platform security lead; financial-institution crypto or CISO lead;

Public sector	5	telecoms or GSMA-track engineer; post-quantum start-up or hardware security module maker.
International and standards	5	National cyber agency cryptography leads (two, from different blocs); a financial-sector regulator; a defence or critical-infrastructure body; a representative from a non-Western or engaged-but-unaligned state. ENISA; the ETSI quantum-safe group; ISO/IEC JTC 1 SC 27; a multilateral financial body (for example the BIS or the G7 Cyber Expert Group); a regional or OECD-level convenor or a post-quantum coalition.

Selection balances the blocs so the review is not dominated by one camp, and mixes standards leads, policy leads and operators so relevance is tested for more than one kind of reader. Conflicts of interest are declared at recruitment, and reviewers choose whether to be named or to remain anonymous in the published acknowledgements.

4. Engagement model

The review follows a light, two-round expert-elicitation design (a modified Delphi). The first round is individual and asynchronous, which respects senior schedules and avoids one voice anchoring the rest. The second round convenes the panel to resolve the points where reviewers disagree, so the outcome reflects considered consensus rather than a first reaction. The whole ask is kept to about one hour per reviewer in round one, with an optional thirty-minute interview for those who prefer to talk.

Reviewers are offered acknowledgement as named expert reviewers, early access to the second edition, and a contribution to a short published validation note. The roundtable runs under the Chatham House rule, so positions can be discussed candidly and reported without attribution.

5. The feedback instrument: two questions and a route to improvement

Every reviewer answers the same two questions, with a structured path from a criticism to an actionable, sourced suggestion.

Question	What is asked	How the reviewer answers
Q1. Is it relevant?	Whether the Atlas is useful, for what purpose, and for whom.	A one-to-five rating with a one-line statement of the use case it serves or fails to serve.
Q2. What is wrong?	What is inaccurate, missing or misleading, across the five objects of review.	Structured flags: for classification, the specific country, its current camp and the suggested camp, with a reason; for the method and the regulatory layer, the specific point contested.
Route to improvement	How to make it more accurate and more authoritative.	For each flag, a 'suggested change plus supporting source plus confidence' field, and one overall prompt: what single change would make this authoritative for your organisation.

Reviewers choose the channel that suits them: a structured online form, inline comments on a shared review copy, a 'suggest a correction' path on the live Atlas keyed to each country, or a recorded interview that the team transcribes. All channels feed a single disposition log, so every comment is captured with its source and routed to a decision. Capturing the source and a confidence level on each suggestion lets the change flow straight into the Atlas verification process.

6. Timeline

Engagement runs from mid-June to 15 September, the hard deadline for all reviewer input, with the validated edition delivered by the end of September.

Phase	Dates (2026)	Activities	Output
0. Set-up and recruitment	17 Jun to 4 Jul	Finalise the review pack and the form; confirm the fifteen experts; consent and conflict declarations; brief the panel.	Confirmed panel; review pack; live feedback instrument.
1. Round 1, individual review	7 to 25 Jul	Distribute the pack and form; run optional interviews; send reminders.	Fifteen completed reviews.
2. Synthesis and draft revision	28 Jul to 15 Aug	Code the feedback; build the disposition log; draft reclassifications and method revisions; mark contested points.	'What we heard' synthesis; draft second edition.
3. Round 2, convening and resolution	18 Aug to 12 Sep	Roundtable under the Chatham House rule and targeted one-to-ones on contested points; collect final corrections.	Resolved positions; final corrections. Input closes 15 Sep.
4. Finalisation and delivery	15 to 30 Sep	Apply changes; re-verify against sources; finalise the outputs.	Validated edition delivered end September.

7. Outputs, end September

The validated edition has five parts: the revised Atlas, with reclassifications applied and confidence grades updated; the companion report, with a new section on the expert validation; a short validation and methodology note that documents the process and shows how each strand of feedback was used; the named (or anonymised) panel of expert reviewers, as a credibility layer; and the disposition log, which records every comment and the decision taken on it. The log matters: it is what lets the project say the Atlas was reviewed by named experts and show exactly what changed as a result.

8. Governance, ethics and authority

Participation is by informed consent, with each reviewer choosing named or anonymous attribution. Conflicts of interest are declared at recruitment and recorded. The roundtable runs under the Chatham House rule. Any material drawn from closed stakeholder settings is used only as anonymised aggregate, consistent with the project's existing confidentiality commitments. Analytical authority stays with the project lead: experts advise, and the lead decides and documents each decision in the

disposition log. Reviewers are advising on a research instrument, not signing off a compliance product.

9. Contributors needed beyond the report

To make the Atlas high-level and to grow its commercial capacity, the project needs contributors in two groups: those who add authority and keep the instrument accurate, and those who turn it into a service. The table marks which roles are needed first.

Credibility and quality

Role	What they add	Priority
Academic or methodological co-lead, or advisory chair	A recognised authority in standards governance or cryptography who co-signs the method and lends standing.	First
Expert advisory board (three to five)	Ongoing governance and credibility beyond the one-off review; a standing source of correction.	First
Data and research analyst	Maintains the corpus, runs the country research, and keeps the classifications current.	First
Software and data engineer	Maintains the site and the update pipeline; builds the 'suggest a correction' tool and automates the rebuilds.	First
Policy and sector analyst	Turns the data into sector briefs (finance, critical infrastructure) where the obligations bite.	Second
Editorial support	Keeps the report, briefs and analysis channel to a regular cadence.	Second

Reach and commercial capacity

Role or partner	What they add	Priority
Commercial or business-development lead	Productises the Atlas: country briefs, a monitoring subscription, bespoke deep-dives; owns partnerships and sales.	First
Partnerships and communications lead	Institutional anchors (a host such as CEPS or a university, and standards bodies) and dissemination.	First
Legal and compliance adviser	Keeps any advisory output sound, and handles data, IP and disclaimers.	Second
Host institution and funding or sponsor partner	An institutional home that confers authority, and resourcing for the engagement and the platform.	First

The minimum viable team to reach a credible, sellable second edition is small: a methodological co-lead or advisory chair, a data analyst, an engineer, and a commercial lead, anchored to a host institution. The advisory board and the sector and editorial roles can follow once the validated edition is in hand and the first advisory engagements are running.